By then Tongpeng-la was under attack. Kaushik, with the two remaining platoons of Delta Company, thought it unlikely that the Chinese would try to attack his position from the right as it was protected by a huge rock face. From their position on the pass, the Sikhs could see the Chinese making their way towards Tongpeng-la, even as they could hear the intense firing from the IB Ridge. After a brief discussion with the commanding officer, Lieutenant Colonel B. N. Mehta decided to move an additional platoon under Havildar Pratap Singh to protect the right flank. However, even though Tongpeng-la was almost three and a half kilometres behind Bum-la, the Chinese obviously had a fairly accurate idea of the terrain. Hoping to catch Delta Company unawares, they had decided to launch their main attack from the right flank, and were using the rock face behind which they were forming up for the attack.

Captain Gosal, however, had ideas of his own and he directed the guns to engage the Chinese forming up behind the rock face. What followed was a classic example of what a determined and competent forward observer can do. The accurate fire by the 7 (Bengal) Mountain Battery took a heavy toll of the massed Chinese troops. Suffering a large number of casualties, the Chinese were forced to give up any thoughts of launching an attack from the right side.

Gathering their dispersed troops, the Chinese now tried to encircle Tongpeng-la and even tried to use snipers to eliminate the observation post party. The three Sikh platoons, once again aided by accurate fire brought to bear by Gosal's guns, successfully broke up the attack. After a lull, during which time the Chinese collected more troops, a third assault was launched on Tongpeng-la at 11.30 a.m., once again from the right, from behind the rock face. For the third time, the OP officer was alert and the guns thwarted the Chinese yet again. With three attacks having failed, the Chinese decided to bypass Kaushik's position at Tongpeng-la; here too, accurate fire from the Sikhs ensured that there could be no progress towards Milaktong.

Four platoons of the Sikhs and one platoon of Assam Rifles had proved what determined, well-dug-in infantry could do. Despite being confined to fixed defensive positions where eventually both Roy and Joginder Singh's platoons were wiped out, the men repeatedly fought off the Chinese.

WE'LL HOLD THEM AT SE-LA NOW